Owing to the quirks of the US electoral system, he became president thanks to the support of just 113,122 voters, or not much more than 2 per cent of adults, and 1 per cent of the total population.[48] In Britain at the same time, only about 400,000 people were eligible to vote for Parliament, or around 6 per cent of the adult population. Moreover, 30 per cent of parliamentary seats were not even contested.[49]

You may wonder whether we are talking about democracies at all. At a time when the United States had more slaves than voters (more than 1.5 million Americans were enslaved in the early 1820s),[50] was the United States really a democracy? This is a question of definitions. As with the late-sixteenth-century Polish–Lithuanian Commonwealth, so also with the early-nineteenth-century United States, 'democracy' is a relative term. As noted earlier, democracy and autocracy aren't absolutes; they are part of a continuum. In the early nineteenth century, out of all large-scale human societies, the United States was probably the closest to the democratic end of the continuum. Giving 25 per cent of adults the right to vote doesn't sound like much today, but in 1824 that was a far higher percentage than in the Tsarist, Ottoman or Chinese Empires, in which nobody had the right to vote.[51]

Besides, as emphasised throughout this chapter, voting is not the only thing that counts. An even more important reason to consider the United States in 1824 a democracy is that compared with most other polities of its day, the new country possessed much stronger self-correcting mechanisms. The Founding Fathers were inspired by ancient Rome – witness the Senate and the Capitol in Washington – and they were well aware that the Roman Republic eventually turned into an autocratic empire. They feared that some American Caesar would do something similar to their republic, and constructed multiple overlapping self-correcting mechanisms, known as the system of checks and balances. One of these was a free press. In ancient Rome, the self-correcting mechanisms stopped functioning as the republic enlarged its territory and population. In the United States, modern information technology combined with freedom of the press helped the self-correcting mechanisms survive even as the country extended from the Atlantic to the Pacific.

It was these self-correcting mechanisms that gradually enabled the United States to expand the franchise, abolish slavery and turn itself into a